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Cite this: *Org. Chem. Front.*, 2021, **8**, 4432

Received 22nd April 2021,
Accepted 1st June 2021

DOI: 10.1039/d1qo00599e

rsc.li/frontiers-organic

Rh-Catalyzed oxidative homo-coupling cyclization of 2,3-allenols to conjugated furylenones†

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An unexpected rhodium-catalyzed highly regio- and stereo-selective bimolecular nucleophilic oxyrhodation/insertion/1,4-Rh migration/β-H elimination reaction of 2,3-allenols affording (2,5-dihydrofuran-3-yl) but-2(*E*)-en-1-one derivatives is reported. Optically active products may be prepared from optically active 2,3-allenols without obvious racemization. The synthetic potentials have been demonstrated.

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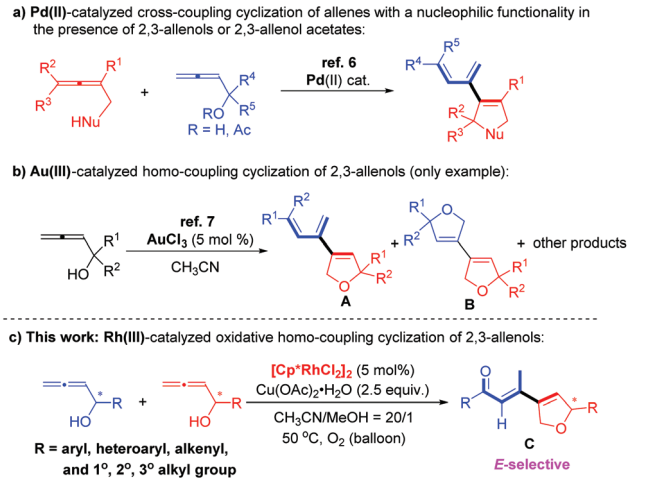
Introduction

Cyclization involving two allenes has become a very important approach for the synthesis of carbo- and hetero-cyclic compounds.[1,2] In this area, Pd(II)-catalyzed cross-coupling cyclization of allenes with a nucleophilic functionality in the presence of 2,3-allenols or 2,3-allenyl acetates leading to highly versatile 2,5-dihydrofuran derivatives[3–5] with a synthetically useful conjugated 1,3-diene moiety[6] has been well established (Scheme 1a). Besides the palladium catalysis, Hashmi and co-workers also realized the cyclization of tertiary 2,3-allenols under the catalysis of $AuCl_3$, affording a mixture of **A**-type monocyclic products and **B**-type double cyclizative coupling products together with other by-products (Scheme 1b).[7] In all these cases, a β-O elimination process occurred to generate conjugated dienes. Here, we wish to report a Rh(III)-catalyzed regio- and stereo-selective bimolecular cyclization of 2,3-allenols, in which one allenol cyclized to form the dihydrofuran ring while the second molecule of allenol provided the conjugated enone unit, affording **C**-type derivatives with an exclusive *E*-selectivity (Scheme 1c).

Results and discussion

Initially, the reaction conditions were optimized using 2,3-allenol **1a** (0.3 mmol) in the presence of $[Cp^*RhCl_2]_2$ (2.5 mol%) in methanol under an air atmosphere. The expected products, such as the homo-coupling cyclization products **A1** and **B1** or the cycloisomerization product **D1**, were not detected, and we merely observed the decomposition of 2,3-allenol **1a** (Table 1, entry 1). When $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (2.0 equiv.) was added, the reaction afforded a new product, which was later identified as enone (*E*)-**2a**, in 15% NMR yield after 36 hours, unexpectedly (Table 1, entry 2). After a series of solvents were screened, it was found that the reaction in CH_3CN gave (*E*)-**2a** in a slightly better yield of 20% with 23% recovery of **1a** (Table 1, entries 3–8).

Considering the possible regeneration of the catalytically active metal catalyst, the reaction was conducted under a pure O_2 atmosphere and a higher yield of (*E*)-**2a** was observed (Table 2, entry 1). Increasing the loading of the Rh-catalyst to 4 mol% led to 38% yield of this product (Table 2, entry 2). Further investigation of some mixed solvents showed that the reaction in CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1) gave the best results (Table 2, entries 3–6). Changing the ratio of CH_3CN/MeOH all failed to improve the yield (Table 2, entries 7 and 8). Further increasing



Scheme 1 Transition metal-catalyzed cross-coupling cyclization of allenes in the presence of allenols or their derivatives.

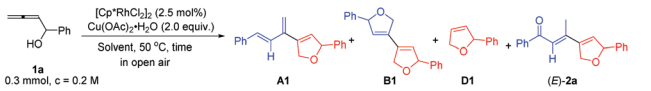
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†Electronic supplementary information (ESI) available. CCDC 1877067. For ESI and crystallographic data in CIF or other electronic format see DOI: 10.1039/d1qo00599e

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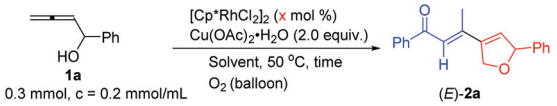
Table 1 Solvent effect[a]



Entry	Solvent	Time (h)	Yield of (*E*)-**2a**[b] (%)	Recovery of **1a**[b] (%)
1[c]	MeOH	14	0	0
2	MeOH	36	15	0
3	DCE	72	15	Trace
4	DMF	72	0	33
5	DMA	72	0	25
6	DMSO	72	2	53
7	Dioxane	72	7	18
8	CH_3CN	72	20	23

[a] Reaction conditions: **1a** (0.3 mmol), $[Cp^*RhCl_2]_2$ (2.5 mol%), and Cu $(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (0.6 mmol) in the solvent (1.5 mL) at 50 °C under an air atmosphere (balloon) unless otherwise noted. [b] Determined by the ^1H NMR analysis of the crude products with mesitylene as the internal standard. [c] Without $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$.

Table 2 Optimization of the reaction conditions under an O_2 atmosphere[a]



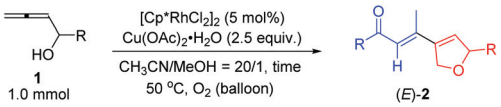
Entry	*x*	Solvent	Time (h)	Yield/recovery (*E*)-**2a**/**1a**[b] (%)
1	2.5	CH_3CN	60	30/9
2	4	CH_3CN	43	38/4
3	4	CH_3CN/H_2O (20/1)	36	20/3
4	4	CH_3CN/HOAc (20/1)	36	40/0
5	4	CH_3CN/NEt_3 (20/1)	36	0/22
6	4	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	36	47/8
7	4	CH_3CN/MeOH (10/1)	41	40/14
8	4	CH_3CN/MeOH (50/1)	41	42/9
9	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	43	49/4
10	6	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	43	47/0
11	7	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	43	38/0
12[c]	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	48	43/3
13[d]	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	38	49/0
14[d,e]	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	60	48 (46)[f]/2
15[d,e,g]	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	38	58 (58)[f]/0
16[d,e,h]	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	12.5	62 (62)[f]/0
17[d,e,i]	5	CH_3CN/MeOH (20/1)	8	60/0

[a] Reaction conditions: **1a** (0.3 mmol), $[Cp^*RhCl_2]_2$ (*x* mol%), and Cu $(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (0.6 mmol) in the solvent (1.5 mL) at 50 °C under an O_2 atmosphere (balloon) unless otherwise noted. [b] Determined by the ^1H NMR analysis of the crude products with mesitylene as the internal standard. [c] $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (1.5 equiv.) was added. [d] $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (2.5 equiv.) was added. [e] 1.0 mmol scale. [f] Isolated yield. [g] 0.48 M. [h] 0.95 M. [i] 1.9 M.

the loading of the Rh-catalyst and $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ showed that 5 mol% of Rh-catalyst and 2.5 equiv. of $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ gave the best result (Table 2, entries 9–13). However, the reaction was rather sluggish when it was scaled up to 1 mmol (Table 2, entry 14). Luckily, performing the reaction at a higher concentration of **1a** remarkably improved the rate and yield, affording (*E*)-**2a** in 62% isolated yield at a concentration of 0.95 M (Table 2, entries 15–17). Thus, the conditions described in entry 16 were chosen as the optimal conditions.

Halogen atoms (F, Cl, and Br) substituted on the *para*-, *ortho*- or *meta*-position of the phenyl groups could all be tolerated, leaving opportunity for further synthetic elaboration (Table 3, entries 2–6). The reaction of allenols bearing an electron-donating group-substituted phenyl group, **1g** and **1h**, afforded the products (*E*)-**2g** and (*E*)-**2h** in 57% and 44% yields, respectively (Table 3, entries 7 and 8). In addition, 2-naphthyl substituted allenol **1i** could also be transformed into (*E*)-**2i** in 52% yield (Table 3, entry 9). Furthermore, heteroaryl groups such as 2-furyl and 2-thienyl substituted allenols also led to the formation of (*E*)-**2j** and (*E*)-**2k** in decent yields (Table 3, entries 10 and 11). Furthermore, the reaction of 1-cinnamyl-2,3-butadienol (*E*)-**1l** resulted in the formation of (*E*,*E*,*E*)-**2l** with four C=C bonds in 41% yield (Table 3, entry 12). Primary alkyl group substituted 2,3-allenols could also react smoothly to afford (*E*)-**2m**–(*E*)-**2r** in 51%–64% yields (Table 3, entries 13–18). Primary alkyl groups containing functionalities such as chlorine and a free hydroxyl group and secondary or tertiary alkyl substituted allenols also worked well (Table 3, entries 19 and 22). A gram-scale reaction could be easily realized (Table 3, entries 6 and 14).

Table 3 The scope of 2,3-allenols[a]

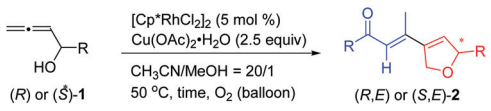


Entry	R	Time (h)	Yield of (*E*)-**2**[b] (%)
1	Ph (**1a**)	12.5	62 ((*E*)-**2a**)
2	**4-F**C_6H_4 (**1b**)	11	57 ((*E*)-**2b**)
3	**2-Cl**C_6H_4 (**1c**)	7.5	53 ((*E*)-**2c**)
4	**3-Cl**C_6H_4 (**1d**)	10.5	54 ((*E*)-**2d**)
5	**3-Br**C_6H_4 (**1e**)	11	53 ((*E*)-**2e**)
6[c]	**4-Br**C_6H_4 (**1f**)	12	52 ((*E*)-**2f**)
7	**4-MeO**C_6H_4 (**1g**)	11	57 ((*E*)-**2g**)
8[d]	Benzodioxol-5-yl (**1h**)	12.5	44 ((*E*)-**2h**)
9	2-Naphthyl (**1i**)	14	52 ((*E*)-**2i**)
10	2-Furyl (**1j**)	12	43 ((*E*)-**2j**)
11	2-Thienyl (**1k**)	11	49 ((*E*)-**2k**)
12	Cinnamyl ((*E*)-**1l**)	13	41 ((*E*,*E*,*E*)-**2l**)
13	*n*-C_6H_{13} (**1m**)	18	64 ((*E*)-**2m**)
14[e]	*n*-C_9H_{19} (**1n**)	13	62 ((*E*)-**2n**)
15	*n*-$C_{11}H_{23}$ (**1o**)	12	63 ((*E*)-**2o**)
16	i-Bu (**1p**)	9	51 ((*E*)-**2p**)
17	Bn (**1q**)	10	54 ((*E*)-**2q**)
18	$(CH_2)_2$Ph (**1r**)	11	62 ((*E*)-**2r**)
19	$(CH_2)_5$**Cl** (**1s**)	12	62 ((*E*)-**2s**)
20	$(CH_2)_5$**OH** (**1t**)	12	56 ((*E*)-**2t**)
21	Cy (**1u**)	12.5	60 ((*E*)-**2u**)
22	*t*-Bu (**1v**)	10	50 ((*E*)-**2v**)

[a] Reaction conditions: **1** (1.0 mmol), $[Cp^*RhCl_2]_2$ (0.05 mmol), Cu $(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (2.5 mmol), and MeOH (50 μL) in CH_3CN (1.0 mL) at 50 °C under an O_2 atmosphere (balloon) unless otherwise noted. [b] Isolated yield. [c] 10 mmol scale, 2 mol% byproduct (*E*)-**8f** was obtained, see the ESI† for details. [d] Besides (*E*)-**2h**, piperonyl aldehyde (3.1 mg, 2%) and a mixture of other byproducts (8.1 mg) were also obtained. [e] 5.82 mmol scale.

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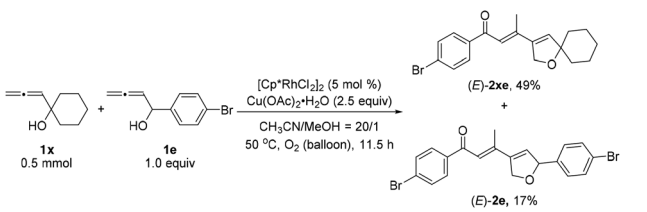
Table 4 Synthesis of optically active (2,5-dihydrofuran-4-yl)but-2-en-1-one derivatives[a,b]



Entry	(*R*) or (*S*)-**1**	Time (h)	(*R*,*E*) or (*S*,*E*)-**2**	Yield (%)	ee (%)
1	(*S*)-**1a**, 98% ee	12.5	(*S*,*E*)-**2a**	56	98
2	(*S*)-**1b**, >99% ee	12	(*S*,*E*)-**2b**	61	>99
3	(*S*)-**1e**, 95% ee	12	(*S*,*E*)-**2e**	48	93
4	(*S*)-**1j**, 96% ee	12	(*S*,*E*)-**2j**	42	95
5	(*R*)-**1m**, 98%	12	(*R*,*E*)-**2m**	61	98
6	(*S*)-**1n**, 96% ee	14.5	(*S*,*E*)-**2n**	67	98

[a] Reaction conditions: **1** (0.5 mmol), $[Cp^*RhCl_2]_2$ (0.025 mmol), $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ (1.25 mmol), and MeOH (25 μL) in CH_3CN (0.5 mL) at 50 °C under an O_2 atmosphere (balloon) unless otherwise noted. [b] Isolated yield.

The cross-coupling reaction of tertiary 2,3-allenol **1x** and secondary 2,3-allenol **1e** afforded the cross-cover product (*E*)-**2xe** in 49% yield together with the homo-coupling product (*E*)-**2e** in 17% yield (eqn (1)).



(1)

The structure of the target molecule was unambiguously determined by the X-ray single crystal diffraction analysis of (*E*)-**2k** (Fig. 1).

As we know, furan rings with chiral centres are very important in pharmaceutical chemistry.[8] With this method, (2,5-dihydrofuran-3-yl)but-2-en-1-one derivatives with a chiral centre could be easily constructed from the readily available optically active starting materials[9] without obvious loss of the enantiomeric purity (Table 4).

To further explore the synthetic utility of this procedure, the reaction was conducted on a 10 mmol scale, affording the product (*S*,*E*)-**2f** (>99% ee) in 50% yield under the standard conditions (Scheme 2). (*S*,*E*)-**2f** is synthetically versatile: the reaction of Cp_2TiMe_2 provided conjugated triene (*S*,*E*)-**3f** in 68% yield.[10] The two different C–Br bonds may be easily differentiated: the Sonogashira coupling of the C–Br bond on the electron-deficient phenyl ring with phenylacetylene gave (*S*,*E*)-**4f** in 78% yield exclusively. The Suzuki coupling of the same C–Br bond with (4-methoxyphenyl)boronic acid afforded the mono-coupling product (*S*,*E*)-**5f** with a selectivity of 12/1 over the double coupling product (*S*,*E*)-**6f**. When 3 equiv. of (4-methoxyphenyl)boronic acid were used, the double Suzuki coupling product (*S*,*E*)-**6f** was obtained in 65% yield exclusively.

In order to gain insight into the mechanism of this transformation, we conducted some control experiments (Scheme 3). When 2-heptyl-2,3-butadienol **1w** was applied under standard conditions, the expected dimeric product (*E*)-**2w** was not observed. Instead, 14% yield of the cycloisomerization product, 3-heptyl-2,5-dihydrofuran **7w**, was isolated, which may be formed *via* the protodemetalation of alkenylrhodium intermediate **IN-1** (Scheme 3, eqn (1)). The unsuccessful cross-coupling cyclization of allenol **1e** with its corresponding allenyl ketone **8e** excludes the formation of *in situ* generated allenyl ketone as the intermediate (Scheme 3, eqn (2)). When the corresponding alcohol **9a** was treated under standard conditions, (*E*)-**2a** was not formed with 87% recovery of **9a**, suggesting that (*E*)-**2a** was not formed *via* oxidation of **9a** (Scheme 3, eqn (3)). The reaction of [D[a]]-**1a** afforded the

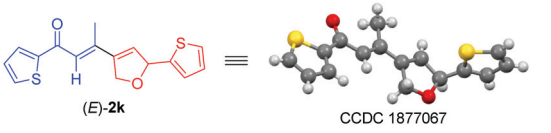
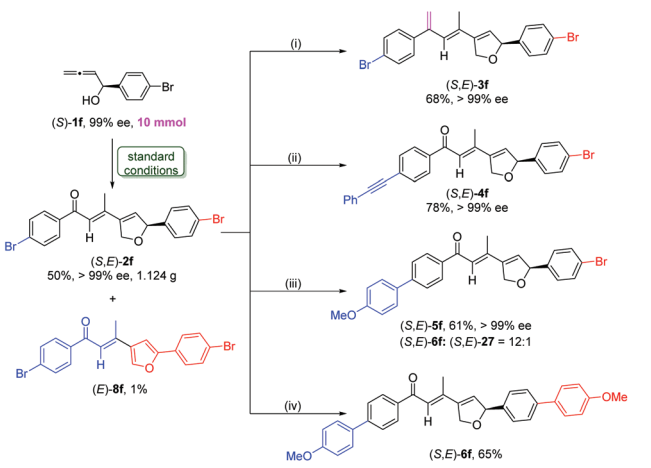


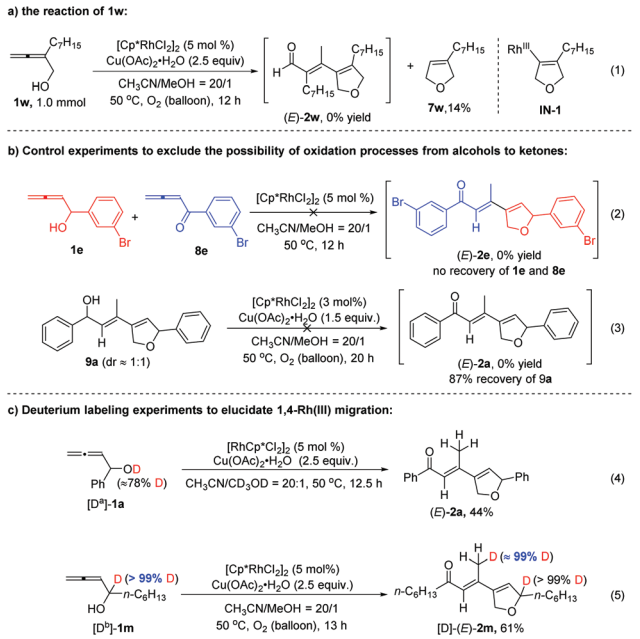
Fig. 1 ORTEP representation of (*E*)-**2k**.



Scheme 2 Synthesis of (*S*,*E*)-**2f** on a gram scale and derivatization reactions. Reaction conditions: All transformations were conducted under a nitrogen atmosphere, (i) Cp_2TiMe_2 (2.0 equiv., 0.1 M in toluene), 65 °C, 15 h; (ii) phenylacetylene (1.3 equiv.), $Pd(PPh_3)_2Cl_2$ (3 mol%), i-Pr_2NH (3 equiv.), CuI (6 mol%), THF, 40 °C, 15 h; (iii) (4-methoxyphenyl)boronic acid (0.91 equiv.), $Pd(PPh_3)_4$ (3 mol%), K_3PO_4 (3 equiv.), dioxane, 85 °C, 13 h; (iv) (4-methoxyphenyl)boronic acid (3 equiv.), $Pd(PPh_3)_4$ (5 mol%), K_3PO_4 (6 equiv.), dioxane, 85 °C, 15 h.

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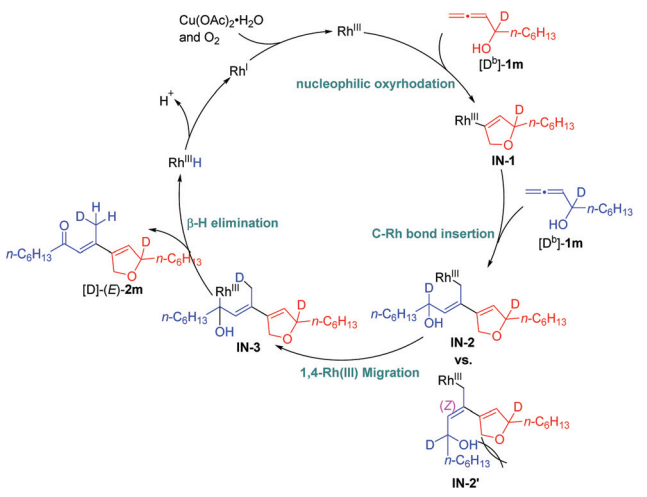
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Scheme 3 Mechanistic studies.

product (*E*)-**2a** without any deuterium incorporation (Scheme 3, eqn (4)). Unexpectedly, the reaction of [D^b]-**1m** afforded [D]-(*E*)-**2m** with a newly formed deuterated group with 99% of D incorporation (Scheme 3, eqn (5)).

Based on these experimental results, a mechanism was proposed as shown in Scheme 4 using [D^b]-**1m** as the substrate. Firstly, 2,3-allenol [D^b]-**1m** underwent a nucleophilic cyclic oxyrhodation to afford the 2,5-dihydrofuran-4-yl-rhodium intermediate **IN-1**, which underwent an insertion reaction with the second molecule of allenol to generate the stereodefined allylic rhodium intermediate **IN-2** stereoselectively by leaving the dihydrofuran ring far away from the bulky hydroxyalkyl group (**IN-2** *vs.* **IN-2′**). This intermediate would form **IN-3** *via* stereo-



Scheme 4 A possible mechanism.

defined 1,4-Rh(III) migration,[11,12] resulting in 1,4-D migration. β-H elimination yielded the final product [D]-(*E*)-**2m** with the generation of the Rh(III)H species. The Rh(III)H species underwent a reductive elimination process to generate a Rh(I) species, which was then oxidized to form the catalytically active Rh(III) species by $Cu(OAc)_2{\cdot}H_2O$ and O_2.[12a–c]

Conclusions

In summary, we have developed the first example of rhodium (III)-catalyzed highly regio- and stereo-selective oxidative dimerization of 2,3-allenols, providing an efficient approach for the synthesis of (2,5-dihydrofuran-3-yl)but-2-en-1-one derivatives. Such a reaction yields completely new products with a broad scope of substrates and good functionality tolerance. The stereoselectivity is determined by the steric effect between the *in situ* formed furan ring and the bulky hydroxyalkyl group. Optically active (2,5-dihydrofuran-3-yl)but-2-en-1-one derivatives are efficiently prepared from the readily available chiral 2,3-allenols. Further studies in this area are currently ongoing in our laboratory.

Conflicts of interest

There are no conflicts to declare.

Acknowledgements

Financial support from the National Natural Science Foundation of China (21690063 and 21988101) is greatly appreciated. Shengming Ma is a Qiu Shi Adjunct Professor at Zhejiang University. We thank Yuan Yuan in our group for reproducing the results of (*E*,*E*,*E*)-**2l**, (*E*)-**2r**, and (*S*,*E*)-**2b**.

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